



**Ahead of the pack:** At the Italian Grand Prix, Max Verstappen crossed the line more than 19 seconds clear, claiming his third win of the season. AP

racing struck the second-placed McLaren cruelly. The Mercedes power unit in Norris's car gave way in the closing stages, with smoke spilling from the rear and with it, his chances of a podium finish. The 25-year-old slumped to the side of the track, visibly frustrated and heartbroken, having seen another optimistic result wither away.

Adding a wholesome element to the final classification was rookie Isack Hadjar, who converted his best-ever starting spot (fourth) into a maiden Formula 1 podium (third). The Racing Bulls driver, who had shown flashes of promise all season, finally pieced together a complete weekend and was duly rewarded.

Verstappen inherited second place, keeping his remarkable home record alive with a fifth consecutive Zandvoort podium — three wins followed by two runner-up finishes. One race into the second half of the season, Piastri had tightened his grip on the championship, while the holder kept himself in contention, with Monza next on the horizon.



### Whispers of revival

Referred to as 'The Temple of Speed' for its long straights and high-speed corners, the Italian Grand Prix bore witness to a historic race that redefined pace and prowess. In a tightly contested qualifying, Verstappen outshone the McLaren drivers and the Ferrari duo with a blistering final lap that set the tone for the weekend. His unbelievable last-gasp effort saw him beat Norris by 0.077s — setting a new lap record around the iconic Monza circuit and posting the fastest lap by average speed in F1 history. His lap time of 1m 18.792s meant an average speed of 264.681 km/h, quicker than the 264.362 km/h Lewis Hamilton set here during qualifying in 2020.

Verstappen had stolen the pole from McLaren, extracting every ounce from the underwhelming Red Bull. The achievement rekindled a determined fire in him, consistent with his aggressive style and never-give-up attitude. Adding more fuel was the fact that no one had won at Monza from pole in the last five Grand Prix, but he was primed for the challenge.

He was on the defensive right from the beginning, but his slow start compromised his position. Having fought a frenetic scrap in the opening laps — during which he lost and regained the lead — Verstappen made no error thereafter, steering clear of both McLaren drivers, who eventually found themselves in a tussle of their

**Dutch drama:** Oscar Piastri won from pole at the Dutch Grand Prix, while Verstappen secured his fifth consecutive home podium at the Zandvoort track. GETTY IMAGES

own. There was late drama as Norris had looked set to finish second until a slow pit stop six laps from the end allowed Piastri to jump ahead. With McLaren eager to protect both cars from Ferrari's Charles Leclerc behind, the team had given the third-placed driver the earlier stop, a move Norris had agreed to, only to see it backfire.

McLaren then ordered Piastri to hand back the position to protect his teammate's title momentum. The 24-year-old questioned the call on the team radio but complied two laps later, allowing Norris to pass in a contentious move. It trimmed his championship lead over Norris by three points to 31. In contrast with qualifying's razor-thin margins, Verstappen crossed the line more than 19 seconds clear, claiming his third win of the season. It was also the fastest race in F1 history, averaging 250.706 km/h — a fitting statistic for the Temple of Speed.

McLaren still secured a double podium, though strategy doubts lingered as both drivers pushed hard for the coveted prize. As for Verstappen, he had reminded the paddock that the fight for 2025 is far from over.